

Democratic Values and Democratic Support in Rapidly Consolidated Democracies: The Case of Taiwan, 1995–2020

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journals.sagepub.com/home/jas**Tsung-han Tsai**

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Abstract

Most of the extant research on the relationship between democratic values and democratic support examine the issue from the perspective of the evolution of democratic culture and institutional learning. These studies conclude that it takes time for people to understand the essence of democracy and to support democracy. We argue that a certain value orientation is crucial to democratic support at some stages of democratic transition. To empirically examine the association between the different dimensions of democratic values and democratic support, we analyzed survey data from 1995 to 2020 in Taiwan. Based on item response theory, we found that, first, throughout that 25-year period, we can distinguish three dimensions of democratic values in Taiwan; second, Taiwanese considered fundamental human rights to be an essential democratic value; and finally, the curvilinear relationship between democratic support and separation of powers implies that Taiwanese people emphasize electoral democracy more than horizontal accountability after democratization is complete.

Keywords

Democratic values, democratic support, item response theory, pluralism, separation of powers

Introduction

It is commonly believed that democracy is the best form of government. In a democracy, individuals have the right to participate in public affairs, to become informed, and to have liberty to speak (Diamond's (1999)). Popular control over government decisions, autonomous organizations, and

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fairly conducted elections are among the important institutional conditions that secure liberal representative democracy (Dahl, 1982, 1988). Moreover, in order to make democracy function well, citizens must express their support for it. Our paper is aimed to explore the influence of democratic values on democratic support across time in one of third-wave democratization: Taiwan.

According to the modernization theory proposed by Lipset (1959) and put in comparative perspective by Inglehart (1988, 1990) and Inglehart and Welzel (2005), economic development supports democracy by encouraging change in cultural values, such as freedom, self-expression, and quality of life. It has been shown that democracy is preceded by socio-cultural changes that result from economic security. A society that places a high value on the principles of democracy may be empowered to influence the government (Jeitschko et al., 2014). Furthermore, some argue that countries in the earlier wave of democratization established political institutions before they introduced competitive elections, whereas the sequence was reversed in countries that came later to democracy. In the absence of the rule of law and a robust civil society, a focus solely on electoral processes alone may lead to incomplete democracy (Rose and Shin, 2001). Their theory suggests that both free elections and the rule of law are fundamental to democracy and the sequence of these two components is crucial to complete democratization. Comprehensive cross-national research confirms that the rule of law is crucial to democratization in developed and under-developed countries (Beal and Graham, 2014).

Based on previous literature on democratic values as well as Taiwanese political culture (Hu and Chu, 1996; Hu et al., 1978), we posit that Taiwanese people's liberal democratic values encompass multiple dimensions: civil liberties, pluralism, and constitutionalism. In addition, we postulate that constitutionalism may not initially play as significant a role in bolstering democratic support as other democratic values, thus aligning with Rose and Shin's (2001) theory. Instead, support for democracy is expressed as support for fundamental human rights in the early and final stage of democratization. To test our hypotheses, we analyzed survey data from Taiwan between 1995 and 2020. As a notable case of third-wave democratization, Taiwan's transition to democracy has been marked by a relatively smooth process of democratic consolidation. Following the first full election of the Legislative Yuan in 1992 (Copper, 1992), the country witnessed a series of peaceful transitions of power between political parties and the establishment of democratic norms and institutions throughout the period 1992–2008. From a close examination of the dimensions of democratic values, we find that civil liberty is widely accepted while pluralism and separation of powers are less recognized. The dimension of pluralism is strongly and consistently associated with public support for democratic regimes through democratization. Separation of powers plays a bigger role in the middle period of democratization, as party turnover occurred.

This article attempts to speak to the literature of democratic support and consolidation. By showing the three dimensions of democratic values across 25 years and each of their contribution to democratic support, we demonstrate that “accepted norms” are one of the qualifications for democratic consolidation.¹ We also try to ascertain whether constitutionalism (rule of law, checks and balances, and so on) emerges before other values or the other way around (Agh, 2001). We intend our research to contribute to the debate on value change by showing that certain democratic values have persisted in Taiwan over the 25 years in question (Inglehart and Welzel, 2005).

The remainder of this article proceeds as follows. In the section “Dimensions of Democratic Values,” we describe the most important dimensions of democratic values discussed in the literature. In the section entitled “Democratic Values and Democratic Support,” we review the literature on the relationship between democratic values and democratic support. “Democratic Values in Taiwan” consists of a discussion of the case of Taiwan. In “Data and Statistical Analysis,” we present our data, statistical models, and the results of our analysis. We draw our conclusions in the final section.

Dimensions of democratic values

There are two categories of research on democratic values. The first examines the domains of democratic values in one country or region, such as rights and institutions (Gibson et al., 1992), institutions and behavior (Fair et al., 2014), electoral and liberal values (Hernández, 2016), the economy and anti-authoritarianism (Oshri et al., 2016), and substantive and procedural conceptions of democracy (Zhai, 2019). The second category uses large-N comparative survey data to discover the relationship between a change in values and democratic development (Inglehart, 1997; Huang et al., 2013; Inglehart and Welzel, 2010). The causal story is that value change takes place prior to change in democratic support (Dalton, 1999, 2000). These two categories of democratic value research highlight the features of democratic values and their influence on democratization, respectively. However, there is a gap between these two approaches. If democratic values are multi-dimensional, which dimension is more important than the others, and how does this change over time?²

Before we explore the dimensions of democratic values and their association with democratic support, we should briefly review the definition of democracy. The previous literature presents at least three essential principles of democracy—liberty and equality; contestation; and constitutionalism, including the separation of powers, rule of law, and accountability. According to Dahl (1971), free and fair elections and effective participation are among the most important conditions for democracy. Contestation is also a fundamental dimension of democracy, according to Coppedge et al. (2008). For Dahl (1998), associational autonomy and inclusive citizenship are conditions of a polyarchal democracy. In Diamond's (1999: 4) view, liberty and democracy should be secured through constitutionalism, limited government, and the rule of law, while for Elster (1993: 6), constitutionalism ensures liberty rights against the executive and legislative branches of government.

Given the multi-dimensional nature of democracy, Rose and Shin (2001) propose a comparative framework of democratic development. They show that the first-wave democracies established accountability, the rule of law, and a civil society before they adopted universal suffrage. In contrast, elections were introduced in countries in the third wave of democratization before they became modern states. This latter sequence of democratic development tends to result in incomplete democracy or even undemocratic regimes.

The framework by Rose and Shin (2001) makes sense of many new democracies' struggle to establish horizontal accountability. O'Donnell (1998: 116) revealed that numerous Latin American nations exhibit deficiencies in horizontal accountability as they transitioned to democratic governance, drawing from models established in Britain, the United States, and France. Often, these nations adopted institutional frameworks from either the formal or informal empires to which they were aligned. Presently, many Latin American countries grapple with challenges in representative democracy, as evidenced by diminished trust in legislative bodies and weakened adherence to the rule of law. Concurrently, there has been a notable surge in dissatisfaction with democratic processes (Zovatto, 2020). In Africa, Sawyer (2008) posited that the formation of alliances and the emergence of new players during the 2005 elections are critical to Liberia's political order in the 21st century. With the power centralized in the president, horizontal accountability remains weak (Signé and Korha, 2016).

Based on the theory by Rose and Shin (2001), we posit that Taiwanese citizens, at the beginning of their democratization process, may not necessarily have prioritized rule of law and separation of powers. Instead, Taiwanese people placed more emphasis on civil liberties (such as freedom of expression, political participation, and equality) as well as pluralism, which is associated with contestation. We anticipate that civil liberty and pluralism are the initial bedrocks of legitimacy of Taiwan's democracy. Separation of powers and other institutional infrastructure support democracy in later phases.

There are abundant empirical studies concerning the dimensions of democratic values. Hu and Chu (1996) conceptualize the value orientation toward a regime in terms of political equality, popular sovereignty, political liberty, political pluralism, and separation of powers. Their research indicates that since 1984, political equality has emerged as the most prominent value among Taiwanese citizens. However, levels of agreement regarding pluralism and separation of powers remain relatively low. Focusing on East Asian countries, Chang et al. (2007) show that the acquisition of liberal-democratic values has been slow, and Shin (2015) points out that, even though citizens generally prefer a democratic regime to an authoritarian one, they also express support for the procedures of authoritarian governance in some circumstances. Furthermore, citizens in Taiwan and South Korea show signs of being “critical citizens” (Chu and Huang, 2010; Sanborn, 2015) in that they embrace liberal attitudes but offer limited support for democratic institutions (Norris, 1999). Kornberg and Clarke (1994) employ confirmatory factor analysis to 10 measures of democratic beliefs in Canada and find that these beliefs have four dimensions. Furthermore, they find that these dimensions of democratic beliefs are associated with different demographic variables. Specifically, education is strongly correlated with the opportunities factor but is not correlated with the election-capitalism one. Hernández (2016) and Kriesi et al. (2016) use electoral process and liberalism to characterize liberal democracy in 30 European countries. Hernández (2016) divides democratic values into five dimensions from 19 items, including electoral, liberal, social justice, direct democracy, and trade-off elements. Like Dahl (1998), his electoral component comprises indicators related to the electoral process, including inclusiveness and differentiated policy proposals. Kriesi et al. (2016) also pointed out that the distribution of demand for liberal democracy is far from homogeneous across countries. Swigger (2013) finds that freedom of speech and privacy are different values for “online citizens,” as they tend to value freedom of speech but downplay privacy. Fair et al. (2014) propose two dimensions of democratic values: institutions (independent courts, being governed by elected representatives, and having civilian control over the military) and behavior (free speech, freedom of assembly, and property rights). Assessing pooled cross-sectional time series data in the 1976–1986 period, Clarke and Dutt (1991) argue that postmaterialism/materialism value is sensitive to short-term economic change. Zhai (2020) finds that satisfaction with Chinese democracy declines more sharply among those who perceive it procedurally between 2008 and 2016.

In brief, democratic values encompass a minimum of three dimensions: civil liberties, pluralism, and constitutionalism. The first dimension captures the essence of democracy and the second one pertains to the behavioral aspects of democracy. Citizens should be allowed to express their opinions and to have multiple parties to choose from. The third dimension pertains to institutions, such as the rule of law and checks and balances that secure liberal representative democracy (Dahl, 1982, 1988). Unlocking the dimensions of democratic values across time may help us understand what democracy means to people in different stages of democratization, something which have consequences for democratic development. The influence of democratic values on democratic support will be elaborated in the next section.

Democratic values and democratic support

Easton's (1965) groundbreaking framework for political systems conceptualizes political interactions within a society as a system surrounded by social and psychological environments. This system, which works under certain types of demands and support, may consist of political communities, regimes, and authorities. It is the members of the political system that express their support for the communities, regime principles, performance, institutions, and political actors. The members offer two kinds of support—specific and diffuse. The former refers to support for

the political authority and the latter is support for the fundamental political arrangements (Easton, 1975). According to Easton (1975: 445), “diffuse support is support that underlies the regime as a whole and the political community.” The health of the political system depends on the level of this diffuse support.

Easton (1975) argues that diffuse support may be defined as a general attachment to an object. It is durable as it does not rise or fall according to performance (Easton 1975: 444). Diffuse support for the political system represents attachment to the political process. It frequently depends on whether democracy is considered to be the best form of government (Dalton, 1999). Research into political culture suggests that the stability of a political system depends on congruence between cultures and institutions. Congruence theory notes that generational replacement may be conducive to pro-democratic values, and that a culture shift would force a political institution to change (Almond and Verba, 1963; Dalton and Shin, 2006).

To compare the conditions for democracy across countries, Almond and Verba (1963) propose a theory of civic culture in which participation is the major element. The more people participate in campaigns and vote, the more stable the democracy. The specifics of civic culture also include belief in one’s ability to influence political decisions and the belief that most citizens are trustworthy. Dahl (1971) argues that the following attributes, among others, are conducive to democracy: belief in the legitimacy of democratic institutions, public contestation, and participation; belief in the relationship between the government and the governed; and confidence in the capacity of the government to deal effectively with the country’s problems. Informal norms and practices are important elements of the civic culture approach in which civic culture indicates democratic well-being (Kingzette and Neblo, 2021). Support for democratic institutions does not automatically increase as democracy evolves, because people often blame institutions for their frustrations (Christmann, 2018; Inglehart and Welzel, 2010).

The above discussion emphasizes the importance of people’s belief in the basic principles of democratic governance, that is, democratic values. Easton (1975: 451) points out that commitment to political rules and institutions is a source of diffuse support. As Inglehart and Welzel (2005: 149) argue, “formal democracy can be imposed on almost any society, but whether it provides genuine autonomous choice to its citizens largely depends on mass values.” When it comes to support for democracy, these values include interpersonal trust and life satisfaction (Inglehart, 1988, 1990), diversity and consensus (Almond and Verba, 1963), and political tolerance and rights consciousness (Gibson et al., 1992). It is argued that democratic values are essential for democracy to endure (Huntington, 1991), and it has been shown that democratic values are strongly related to regime support, controlling for quality of governance and level of democratic development (Chang et al., 2013). As Dalton succinctly puts it, “Democratic political systems must keep the support of their citizens if they are to remain viable” (Dalton, 1999: 59).

The rise of radical leftist groups in the 1970s and 1980s presented a major challenge to democratic processes in Europe and America (Crozier et al., 1975). In the 21st century, Latin America and North America have experienced multiple surges of populism, posing fundamental challenges to the legitimacy of representative democracy. In recent years, scholars have paid closer attention to the phenomena associated with democratic backsliding, such as weakening checks on the power of the executive and constraints on civil liberties (Haggard and Kaufman, 2021). Some scholars suspect that the decrease in democratic support is due to public dissatisfaction with the authority rather than with democratic institutions. Since macroeconomic stability is considered to be vital to the stability of democracy (Inglehart, 1988; Muller and Seligson, 1994), it is argued that economic growth is conducive to positive democratic values and vice versa (Inglehart and Welzel, 2005, 2010). More specifically, good economic performance is strongly associated with public satisfaction with democracy (Anderson and Guillory, 1997; Christmann, 2018; Finkel et al., 1989).

From this perspective, the fundamental belief in democracy declines when people are dissatisfied with government performance. In other words, diffuse support is not as durable as Easton (1975) expected.³ Hence, it is imperative to examine the change in democratic support over time and find out what contributes to the persistence of democracy.

It has been found that there are cross-cultural differences in terms of interpersonal trust and support for democracy (Inglehart, 1988, 1990). What is more, people may value certain principles more than others at different times, and different people may give the same principles different weights (Thomassen, 2007: 429). In other words, some value orientations may have a larger impact on democratic legitimacy even if there is no change in the aggregate level of democratic values in a society. For example, Gibson et al. (1992) emphasize political tolerance and rights consciousness among other values that have affected people's support for the norms of democracy in the states of the former Soviet Union.

Support for democracy has little meaning unless it is brought into a specific context (Swigger, 2013: 593). Different contexts may give rise to different norms and different levels of belief in democracy. Some studies have tried to decompose people's belief in democracy. For example, Chu et al. (2008) explore the meaning of democracy in China, Hong Kong, Taiwan, and five other countries. They find that democracy is perceived as a mixture of participation, liberty, and political rights. We noted above that the importance of civil liberties, autonomous organizations, and the separation of powers have all been mentioned during various historical periods. They apply to the development of democracy from the city-state with its face-to-face contact to the nation-state in which delegation is necessary (Dahl, 1982). Below, we will discuss democratic values in Taiwan.

Democratic values in Taiwan

To investigate democratic values in different phases of democratic development and the relationship between democratic values and support for democracy, we select Taiwan for our case study. Like Poland, Korea, and other developing countries, Taiwan experienced mass value shift in the 1990s as its economic growth brought in culture change (Inglehart and Welzel, 2005). Before then, Taiwan had a one-party regime that controlled the police, the military, the justice system, and government. Although civil liberties and rights were guaranteed in the constitution, under martial law, the regime restricted freedom of speech, disregarded the rule of law, and violated human rights. After martial law was lifted in 1987 and the Temporary Provisions Effective During the Period of Communist Rebellion were abolished in 1991, civil liberties and political rights were better protected. In 1992, Taiwan held its first full parliamentary election, which marked the turning point in its democratic transition (Hsieh and Niou, 1996). In 1996, the first presidential election was held. Since then, democracy has evolved toward consolidation (Rigger, 2011). According to Diamond (1999), democratic consolidation requires consensus on the democratic process at the elite, organization, and mass levels. After the first transfer of power in 2000 and the second in 2008, Taiwan's democratic consolidation was close to completion (McAllister, 2016). Freedom House (2022) describes Taiwan as "a vibrant and competitive democratic system that has allowed three peaceful transfers of power between rival parties since 2000 and has robust protections for civil liberties." In other words, Taiwan's democracy has evolved to near consolidation in less than 20 years.

Scholars have sought to discover and explain the extent to which Taiwanese people in Taiwan subscribe to democratic values and how many show a cynical disregard for politics (Chu and Diamond, 1999; Hu and Chu, 1996). Idealism and moral values drove democratic transition (Wu, 2000). Although many Taiwanese people have embraced democratic values, others still value stability and authority (Hsieh, 2002; Hsieh and Niou, 1996). There are also some studies on the

long-term development of democratic values in Taiwan. For example, Sheng (1992) analyzes several survey datasets from 1983 to 2001 and finds that democratic values fluctuate with party turnover. However, he does not find any evidence that supporters of the opposition party have a lower level of democratic values. Applying item response theory (IRT) to three waves of the Asian Barometer Survey (ABS), Chang (2011) finds an increase in the level of democratic values and a strong association between education and democratic values. Chu and Shin (2005) examined survey data collected between 1996 and 2003 in Korea and Taiwan. They find that citizens of the two countries do not fully endorse the principles of rule of law. Hu and Chu (1996) suggest the notion of “uneven growth of mass belief in democratic values” because pluralist values, political liberty and separation of powers are not widely held by Taiwanese people in the 1990s. Chen and Hsu (2016:41) contend that power turnover only strengthens the judiciary, and argue that it is difficult to uphold horizontal accountability because it is shared by the Legislative Yuan, Control Yuan, and Judicial Yuan.

There are two potential factors driving Taiwanese people’s democratic values. The first factor is rooted in traditional culture. According to Hu et al. (1978), Confucianism traditionally emphasizes political order and stability within a hierarchical political system. Under the influence of the authoritarian regime, which promoted Chinese nationalism, Taiwanese society inherited a political culture that places less emphasis on the rule of law. In addition, Chu et al. (2008: 31–32) suggested that Asian societies, including Taiwan, have struggled to fully embrace the concept of the rule of law due to a historical tradition of a strong state.

The second factor is the phase of political development. As observed by Rose and Shin (2001), countries experiencing third-wave democratization often prioritize the establishment of electoral democracy over the development of horizontal accountability mechanisms. Consequently, Taiwan has exhibited a similar pattern of weak checks and balances during the initial stages of democratization, mirroring the experiences of many other emerging democracies.

We argue that, following the literature, democratic values are associated with democratic support. Thus, our first hypothesis is:

H1: People with higher levels of democratic values are more likely to support democracy.

However, not all of the dimensions of democratic values are necessarily associated with democratic support through democratization. Since most people in Taiwan subscribe to civil liberties and pluralism in the beginning, we expect to find higher democratic support among people holding the value of civil liberties and pluralism in the earlier stage of democratization. In contrast, constitutionalism such as separation of powers is likely to be more influential on the level of support for democratic regimes after party turnover took place.⁴ When citizens believe that their rights are safeguarded and that laws are uniformly enforced regardless of the ruling party, they tend to express greater confidence in the democratic process. As democratic norms become ingrained in society and political culture, societies may shift their focus to addressing other pressing challenges, such as political rights and equality. As discussed above, Taiwan’s democratic consolidation was close to completion after the third party turnover in 2016. Therefore, our second and third hypotheses are formulated as follows:

H2a: People with higher levels of belief in individual rights are more likely to support democracy before the first power turnover.

H2b: People with higher levels of belief in the separation of powers are more likely to support democracy after the first power turnover.

According to Diamond (1999: 212), the causality between democratic legitimacy and political culture has yet to be established. These three hypotheses are mainly concerned with the association between democratic support and democratic values. Using cross-sectional individual-level data instead of panel data, the goal of our analysis is to quantify the association between democratic values, as a package or otherwise, and democratic support while holding other variables constant at different time points.⁵

Data and statistical analysis

Here, we are interested in whether people in a society subscribe to all or some dimensions of democratic values and how the dimensions are related to democratic support across times. By examining the dimensions of democratic values, we can discover whether people's value orientations remain stable as the political regime becomes more democratic. To empirically examine the Taiwan public's democratic values in different periods of time, we analyzed data from the Taiwan Social Change Survey (TSCS) Project collected in six waves—1995, 2000, 2005, 2010, 2015, and 2020. These data were collected through face-to-face interviews, and the sizes of the nationally representative samples were 2093, 1960, 2146, 1895, 2034, and 1855, respectively.⁶

Measurement of democratic values

To measure citizens' democratic values, we selected nine items used in all six waves of the survey. The nine items are listed below, together with a brief description in parentheses:

1. Political decisions should be left to those who are older (Elders make decisions, ELDER).
2. We should follow all the government's decisions on national affairs (Follow government's decisions, FOLLOW).
3. Violent offenders should be punished immediately without a trial (Punish without trial, PUNISH).
4. If people have different opinions, society will become chaotic (Different opinions lead to chaos, MULTIOPN).
5. The government has the right to decide if certain utterances or opinions can be allowed to circulate in society (Government controls opinion, CONTROL).
6. Stability will be affected if there are many opposing groups in a region (Opposing groups affect stability, OPPGROUP).
7. If there are several political parties in a country, it will lead to political chaos (Several parties lead to chaos, MULTIPARTY).
8. If the council or assembly is always interfering with the government, then it is impossible for it to achieve much (Legislature's interference in achievement, COUNINTER).
9. When a judge imposes a sentence in an important case that affects the safety of society, he or she should accept the executive body's opinion (Judge accepts executive's opinion, JUNDEREXE).

The nine items were developed according to three basic principles of a political regime: (1) the legitimate power relationship among members of the political community; (2) the legitimate power relationship between the authorities and citizens; (3) the legitimate power relationship among the government branches themselves (Hu and Chu, 1996: 28–29). In this article, we term these three dimensions as pluralism, civil liberty, and separation of powers, respectively.

Table 1. Percentages of disagreement and agreement with the nine measures of democratic values.

Item	1995	2000	2005	2010	2015	2020
1. Elders make decisions (ELDER)	67.35 20.95	75.79 12.31	67.17 23.31	71.94 23.14	65.97 24.62	72.80 20.27
2. Follow government's decisions (FOLLOW)	57.15 33.04	57.29 30.80	63.24 28.95	71.37 24.86	68.11 24.38	60.95 33.60
3. Punish without trial (PUNISH)	33.37 57.42	25.81 65.66	28.97 65.87	32.45 64.78	25.44 69.98	29.54 66.56
4. Different opinions lead to chaos (MULTIOP)	30.45 61.72	32.80 58.19	32.16 63.00	34.93 63.34	36.29 59.23	33.00 64.46
5. Government controls opinion (CONTROL)	51.96 30.61	56.07 27.67	60.32 30.75	69.36 25.63	66.94 24.78	65.03 29.97
6. Opposing groups affect stability (OPPGROUP)	29.70 61.57	31.22 57.59	32.88 60.54	36.20 60.54	35.05 59.11	34.30 61.60
7. Several parties lead to chaos (MULTIPARTY)	49.28 39.89	50.26 38.31	46.38 46.11	51.36 45.26	47.41 46.65	48.67 46.78
8. Council's interference in achievement (COUNINTER)	39.69 41.24	39.10 41.98	42.95 47.49	48.30 44.16	40.09 49.55	42.17 48.25
9. Judge accepts executive's opinion (JUNDEREXE)	53.43 24.74	50.06 27.77	54.86 32.64	54.62 38.58	50.04 38.55	44.10 45.94

Percentages for "disagree" are listed above those for "agree." Percentages for nonresponses are not shown. Data are weighted to reflect the characteristics of the national population.

According to the discussions in the literature, democratic values are treated as a multi-dimensional, latent variable and usually measured by a set of manifest variables. Based on the nine items listed above, we can see that the items ELDER, FOLLOW, and CONTROL are concerned with freedom of expression, which is one of the components of liberalism. Liberty and equality are considered to be fundamental values of democracy and are usually seen as twin concepts although they stand for two different strands of thought in democratic theory (Thomassen, 2007). Second, the items MULTIOP, OPPGROUP, and MULTIPARTY involve the concept of pluralism, which some people believe makes a positive contribution to democracy while others do not (Almond and Verba, 1963; Dahl, 1971). Pluralism means that citizens should have more than one dominant group that they can choose from because it is assumed that interest groups, the government, and the mass media work together in the public interest. Finally, the items PUNISH, COUNINTER, and JUNDEREXE are related to institutions. The item PUNISH is specifically associated with the rule of law and the items COUNINTER and JUNDEREXE are related to the separation of powers and checks and balances.

Expressing agreement with the nine items (the responses "strongly agree" and "agree") implies that the respondent has a lower level of democratic values, while disagreeing with them ("strongly disagree" and "disagree") implies a higher level of democratic values. The percentages for disagreement and agreement are displayed in Table 1. From these data, we can see, first of all, that the majority of Taiwanese people generally disagree with the items ELDER, FOLLOW, and CONTROL. In other words, they value fundamental human rights such as freedom of expression and free participation. Second, a majority agree with the items MULTIOP and OPPGROUP and the distribution of agreement and disagreement is approximately equal for MULTIPARTY. This result suggests that pluralism is not yet generally accepted. One surprising result is the one for MULTIPARTY. The percentages of respondents agreeing with this were greater than those

disagreeing in 1995 and 2000. But the percentage of those expressing agreement gradually increased over time. Finally, a majority of respondents agreed with the items PUNISH and COUNINTER. Moreover, although a majority disagreed with the item JUNDEREXE in five of the six surveys, the percentages for agreement and disagreement were approximately the same in 2020. These results indicate that the Taiwanese people lack awareness of the rule of law and are not fully aware of the importance of the separation of powers.

Overall, the results in Table 1 imply that democratic values concerning freedom of expression and autonomy in the policy-making process are stronger than other values among Taiwanese. Pluralism may be less emphasized, as some individuals perceive a thin boundary between diversity and chaos. Furthermore, how democratic institutions really work may be remote from people's daily lives. These trends concerning democratic values have been quite consistent over the past 25 years. To some extent, the results of the surveys correspond to the "Asian version of democracy" (Chang et al., 2007; Chu and Shin, 2005; Shin, 2015). Constitutionalism is not fully recognized yet. As Chu and Shin (2005: 200) put it, "In both Taiwan and Korea, the mechanisms of horizontal accountability are not well-developed."

Then, to examine democratic values more closely, we employed the methods of IRT to determine the characteristics of the above nine items, thereby constructing scores for democratic values. IRT takes the differences in the difficulty of items into account when estimating the latent variable. Moreover, with the same distributional assumption of latent variable and the fixed values of some item parameters (or latent traits), the estimates of parameters can be compared across time.

We recoded the responses to these nine items as dichotomous (agreement and disagreement) and used a two-parameter logistic (2PL) item response model to estimate the item parameters and the latent variable in an assumed unidimensional space (Lord, 1968).⁷ The 2PL-IRT model can be represented by the cumulative distribution function of the logistic distribution as follows

$$\Pr(z_{i,k} = 1 \mid \theta_i, \alpha_k, \beta_k) = \frac{\exp[\beta_k (\theta_i - \alpha_k)]}{\{1 + \exp[\beta_k (\theta_i - \alpha_k)]\}}$$

where $z_{i,k} = 1$ denotes respondent i 's disagreement with the statement of item k , β_k indicates the item-discrimination parameter, α_k indicates the item-difficulty parameter, and θ_i denotes the latent variable (Embretson and Reise, 2000). One of the advantages of IRT is that the characteristics of items can reflect the levels of latent traits, which is appropriate for evaluating democratic values by the performance of items.

To compare the items across the six waves, we first analyzed the 1995 data, then analyzed the remaining data with the two item parameters of item ELDER fixed to the estimates from 1995. In other words, item ELDER is treated as the "anchor" in our analysis.⁸ In the following, we focus on the parameters of item difficulty. In IRT models, when the level of latent trait is equal to the parameters of item difficulty, individuals have a 0.5 probability of being $z = 1$. As the level of latent trait rises, the probability of $z = 1$ also rises, given that the parameters of item difficulty are fixed. In the context of a discussion of democratic values, this means that higher levels of democratic values are required to disagree with the more "difficult" items.

The estimates of item-difficulty parameters are shown in Figure 1.⁹ We find that, first of all, ELDER is a relatively "easy" question, implying that only a low level of democratic values is required for a respondent to express disagreement with the statement. Second, PUNISH is a relatively "hard" question, which means that a higher level of democratic values is required to express disagreement with it. Third, MULTIOP, OPPGROUP, MULTIPARTY, and COUNINTER are "intermediate" questions, indicating that a higher-than-average level of democratic values is

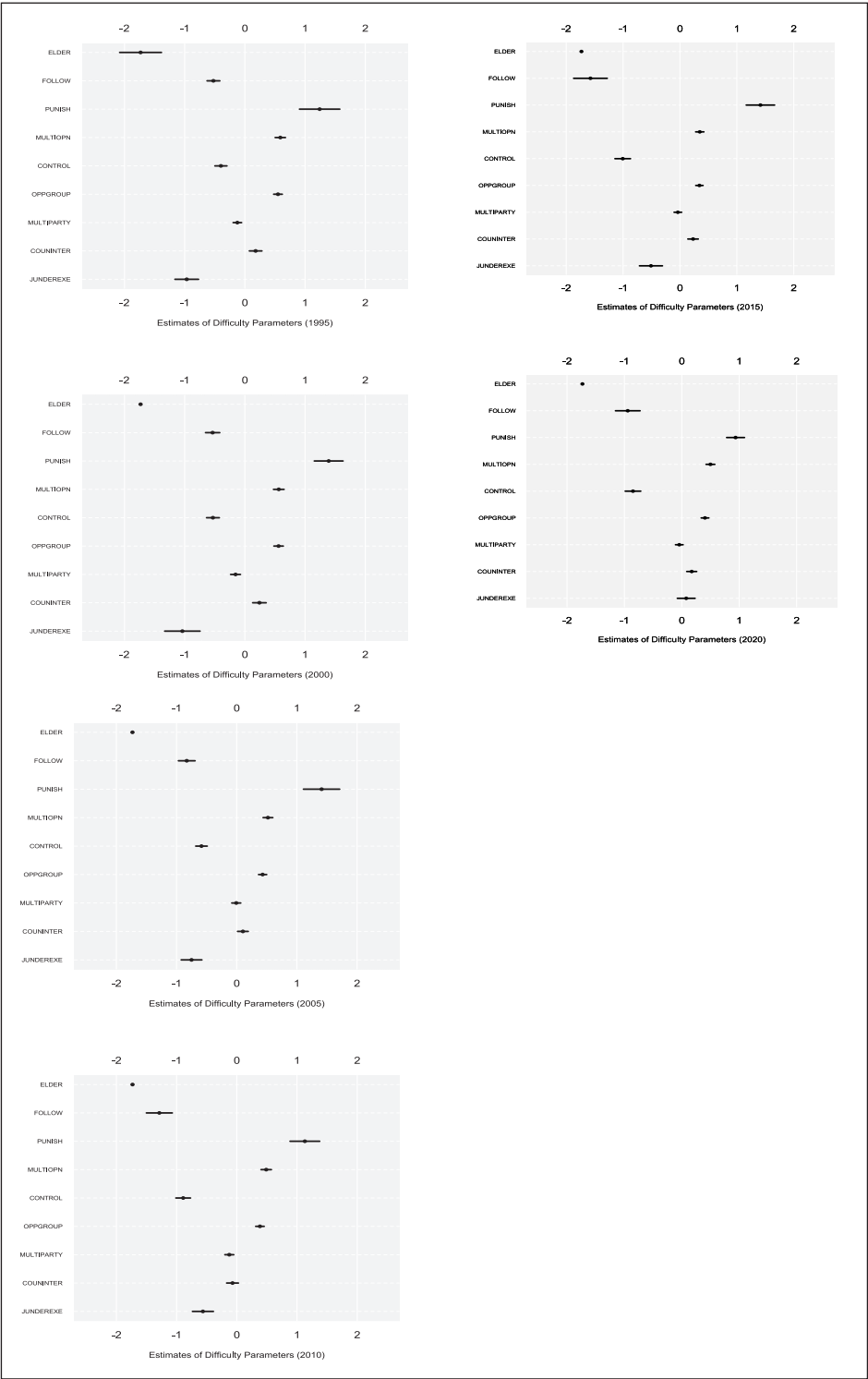


Figure 1. The estimates of item-difficulty parameters (1995–2020); the lines are 95% confidence intervals.

required to disagree with the statements. Fourth, given that item ELDER is fixed, we find that the characteristics of these five items are quite consistent over the 25 years in question.

The difficulty of the remaining three items—FOLLOW, CONTROL, and JUNDEREXE—changes gradually over time. FOLLOW and CONTROL change from being moderately difficult items to being relatively easy ones, which indicates that an increasing number of people espouse popular sovereignty and consider government restrictions on freedom of expression to be inappropriate. In contrast, JUNDEREXE changes from an easy item to an intermediate one, which means that more people are undervaluing the separation of powers and accepting that the executive should have power over judicial decisions in order to ensure the safety and stability of society.

In sum, overall democratic values did not change markedly in Taiwan over the 25-year period. Most Taiwanese agree that civil liberties such as autonomy and freedom of expression are fundamental to democracy. However, they generally do not hold strong values concerning pluralism and democratic procedures. Specifically, people tend to prioritize stability over pluralism and executive power over the power of the legislature and the judiciary. This finding suggests that the evolution of democratic values in Taiwan is not yet complete. One possible explanation for this is the legacy of authoritarianism, because one of the key features of authoritarianism is concentration of power in the executive branch, which is often credited with contributing to Taiwan's economic success (Shin, 2015).

Regression analysis of democratic support

We then examined the relationship between democratic values and democratic support. It has been argued that people with higher levels of democratic values are more likely to express support for democratic regimes (Inglehart and Welzel, 2005). As we discussed above, democratic values can be divided into three dimensions within the nine indicators used in the case of Taiwan. Most Taiwanese people have a value orientation in favor of fundamental human rights while only a minority are oriented toward pluralism and the separation of powers.

We are interested in the relationship between democratic values and public support for democracy, especially how each of the three dimensions of values are related to democratic support. The outcome variable in our analyses is support for democracy, for which the classic Eurobarometer item is used (Molino and Montero, 1995: 233–236). The wording of this item in Eurobarometer and TSCS is: “We would like to know your opinion about democracy. Of the three statements listed on the card, which one comes closest to your view? (1) under any circumstances, democracy is the best system; (2) under certain circumstances, dictatorship is better than democracy; (3) to me, all political systems are the same.” Many other researchers have adopted this measurement in their comparative analyses, including Linz and Stepan (1996: 136), Gunther and Montero (2004), and Schedler and Sarsfield (2004).

As Figure 2 shows, the distributions of the third option “all the same” are about 25% and relatively stable across the period. In contrast, support for democracy and authoritarianism fluctuates in this period. The distribution of support for democracy dropped after 2005 and fell below 50% in 2015, whereas the distribution of support for authoritarianism rose above 20% in 2010 and 2015. In addition, the percentage of missing increased from 2% to 5% after 2015.

In the analysis by Linz and Stepan (1996: 142) of the new democracies of southern Europe and the study by Asomah and Dim (2021: 2583) on democratic consolidation of Ghana, support for democracy was coded as a dichotomous variable. “Under any circumstances, democracy is the best system” was coded as “1” (*support*), while the other two statements were coded as “0” (*No support*). In our analyses, we also recoded the responses into two categories: democracy is preferable

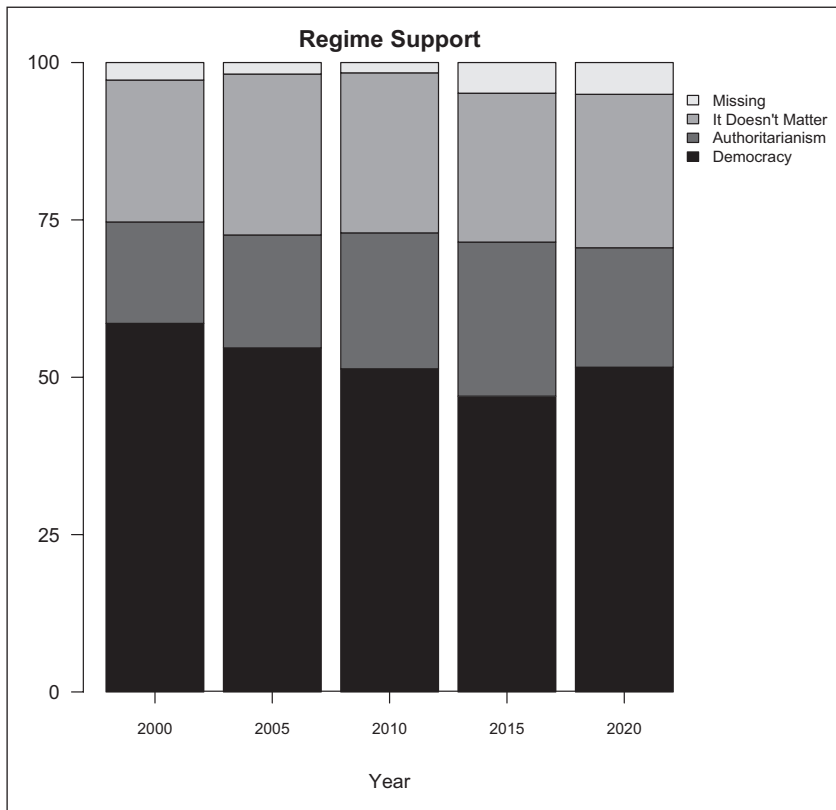


Figure 2. The distributions of democratic support from 2000 to 2020.

and democracy is not preferable. Option (1) indicates democracy is always preferable while options (2) and (3) imply that democracy is not preferable, at least under certain circumstances. We assume that democratic values are associated with preference for democracy over either authoritarianism or no preference. In other words, an increase in democratic values should decrease the odds of choosing no preference or authoritarian regime over democracy.

The main explanatory variable in our analyses is democratic values. For the purpose of simplification, we recoded the responses to these nine items as dichotomous, as we did for the IRT analysis above. To show that value orientations matter, we used two strategies for measuring democratic values, given the assumption that democratic values are a latent variable measured by the nine manifest variables. The first strategy assumes that democratic values are a unidimensional, latent variable. The second strategy distinguishes between the three dimensions as discussed above.¹⁰

We applied the logit model to the dichotomous outcome variable. In the analyses, we also included some control variables that are considered to affect support for democracy. These variables are public satisfaction with democracy, assessment of national level of democracy, party affiliation, education level, and age.¹¹ We only display the results of the main explanatory variables in Figure 3. The tables of coefficient estimates are presented in Supplemental Appendix B.

Several findings from the empirical analyses displayed in Figure 3 are summarized as follows. First, when democratic values are assumed to be unidimensional, people with higher levels of democratic values are more likely to say they prefer democracy than to say either that an authoritarian

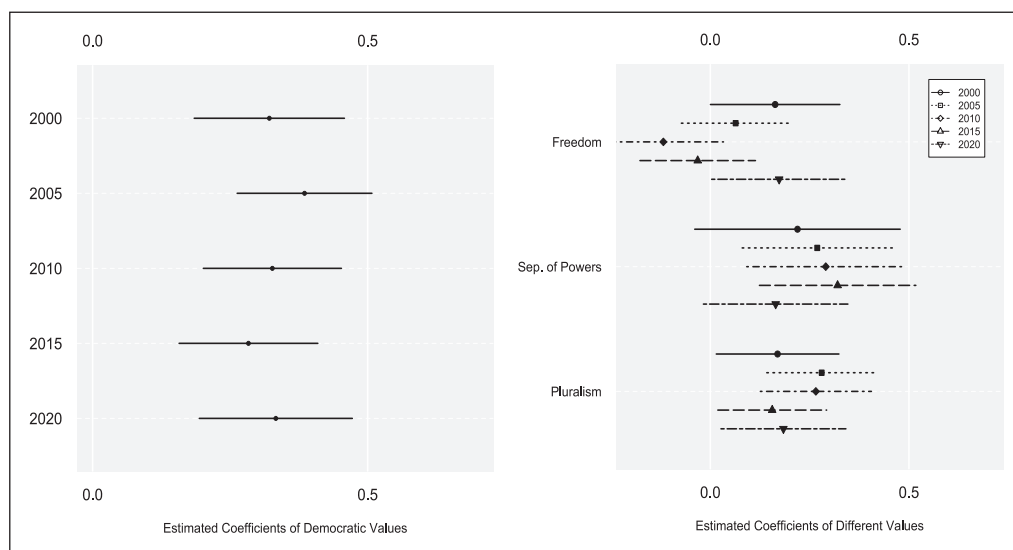


Figure 3. The estimates of regression coefficients. The left panel shows the estimates of unidimensional democratic values and the right panel shows the estimates of multi-dimensional democratic values.

regime is preferable or that all regimes are the same. This result shows that democratic values as a whole contribute to the legitimacy of democracy.

Second, when we distinguish between the three dimensions of democratic values, we observe that people who value freedom of expression are more likely to express a preference for democracy in 2000 and 2020. We do not observe the same relationship in 2005, 2010, and 2015. This result suggests that support for democracy is expressed as support for fundamental human rights in the early stage of consolidation and when consolidation is complete.

Third, we observe an opposite phenomenon for separation of powers. Specifically, separation of powers is positively correlated with democratic support in 2005, 2010, and 2015, but not in 2000 and 2020. Separation of powers is an important value in democratic support during this period probably because of the first party turnover in 2000 and the second in 2008. However, people seem to evaluate democracy less from this perspective after three peaceful transfers of power and several constitutional amendments.

Finally, those who support pluralism are also supportive of democracy across the 20 years. It has been shown that democracy is consistently expressed in terms of pluralism and that belief in diversity and contestation is critical to support for democracy. However, civil liberties may be emphasized by elites when they are pushing forward democracy during the transition period and may be revived later when a new generation calls for more labor rights, gender equality, equality for indigenous peoples, and equality across the generations.

In sum, support for democracy in Taiwan is consistently expressed in terms of pluralism. Taiwanese people also value fundamental civil liberties such as freedom of expression and autonomy. Judicial power is also essential for democracy; people who disagree that criminals should be punished without trial tend to prefer democracy over an authoritarian regime. Our analysis provides clinching evidence that Taiwanese democratic support has mainly been driven by pluralism and separation of power, especially between 2005 and 2015. The curvilinear relationship between democratic support and separation of powers implies that Taiwanese people emphasize electoral democracy more than horizontal accountability after democratization is complete.

Conclusion

The cultural approach to discussions of the relationship between democratic values and democratic development may fail to take into account the multiple domains of democratic values. Another approach would be to emphasize the dimensions of democratic values, but there has yet to be a case study on the relative relevance of democratic values over time. We are therefore motivated to observe the evolution of democratic values in Taiwan, which began its transition to democracy in the early 1990s and achieved consolidation late in the first decade of the 21st century. This article uses the IRT model to investigate different dimensions of democratic values in Taiwan and distinguishes three dimensions: civil liberties, pluralism, and separation of powers. By analyzing survey data across 25 years in Taiwan, covering the periods of democratic transition and democratic consolidation, we find that, first, there has been no dramatic change in democratic values over the period. Most Taiwanese value freedom of expression above pluralism or democratic procedures. Second, the values of pluralism and the rule of law contributed to public support for democracy in the early stage of democratization and the period of democratic consolidation, respectively.

Our empirical analysis has several implications. First, although we can treat democratic values as a latent variable measured by a number of indicators, it is essential to distinguish between the different aspects of democratic values and their association with other variables. With more micro-level cross-national data, we should be able to explore whether the extent to which people share certain democratic values depends on their personality, socioeconomic status, identity, or some mixture of those factors. Second, the finding concerning the relationship between each of the three dimensions and support for democracy is mixed. Pluralism is the most salient dimension, but separation of powers also plays an important role. This might reflect a change in the context; Taiwanese people are gradually learning the conditions for democracy through the practice of democratic development. The finding that a multi-party system is tied to support for democracy implies that party competition may prevent democracy from backsliding in Taiwan. Finally, it is revealed that, compared to civil liberties, few Taiwanese subscribe to the separation of powers. Although the democratic system functions well in Taiwan, democracy may not become more deeply embedded if the executive branch is not held accountable by countervailing institutions, such as the judicial and legislative branches. This opens an avenue for future research on public attitudes toward the powers granted to the various branches of government.

This study introduces a methodological framework for examining people's beliefs in the rule of law, civil liberties, and pluralism across different historical periods. Drawing from our literature review, this approach demonstrates potential for implementation in new democracies in Africa and Latin America, where horizontal accountability is often less pronounced compared to electoral democracies. The nonlinear correlation observed between rule of law and support for democracy reflects the rise of populism in these regions. Furthermore, our findings contribute to comprehending the unique dynamics of "Asian-style democracies," elucidating how traditional political norms can influence the adoption of modern democratic principles. In conclusion, this study underscores the importance of considering historical context and cultural factors in shaping democratic development, highlighting avenues for future research in understanding and forging democratic governance.

Our analysis using IRT confirms the relatively weaker presence of constitutionalism, as previously suggested by Hu and Chu (1996), Chu and Shin (2005), and Chu et al. (2008). However, we have found evidence indicating that the separation of powers correlates with increased support for democracy following the first party turnover. This suggests that despite the influences of statism and electoral democracy, as suggested by Chu et al. (2008) and Rose and Shin (2001), respectively, citizens are capable of embracing new democratic values after major political change. It remains

uncertain whether legislative supervision and judicial supremacy will gain widespread acceptance, particularly in light of the divided government that emerged after the 2024 presidential and legislative elections. In that case, it warrants additional investigation into the interaction between democratic values and mass political behavior.

This research has two major limitations. First of all, we have not explored the interaction effect between democratic values and partisanship. If it is found that the heterogeneity effect of partisanship is crucial to democratic support, we may be able to better understand the role of party system in the sense of horizontal accountability. The second limitation is that we have not modeled the dynamics of democracy. We should consider the influence of generation, life cycle, and cohort when we estimate the effect of democratic values on support for democracy. If we do that, all the elements of democracy, like pieces of a puzzle, will fall into place.

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Supplemental material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. We owe the concept of democratic consolidation to Linz and Stepan (1996: 9–11). According to their conceptualization, there are five conditions for consolidated democracy: a lively and independent civil society; habituation to the norms and procedures of democratic conflict regulation; a necessary degree of autonomy and independence for civil and political society supported by the rule of law; a functioning state and a state bureaucracy considered usable by the new democratic government; and a set of socio-politically crafted and socio-politically accepted norms, institutions, and regulations.
2. Zhai (2020) investigated Chinese people's perception of democracy as substantive and procedural, and its longitudinal changes from 2008 to 2016. It is shown that substantive perception is increasing and procedural one is declining. While public satisfaction with democracy declined, the level of satisfaction with democracy among those who perceive it procedurally has declined in larger degree.
3. Easton (1975: 445) argues that long-time discontent with government performance will erode attachment to the system. He also points out that sudden frustration can harm loyalty to the system. However, he does not specify the length of discontent and the magnitude of sudden frustration.
4. Accountability problems may arise when there is a divided government or a populist leader who can control both the executive and legislative branches without significant challenges from his or her party (Rigger, 2011). Bush (2021) points out that the division within and between major parties makes it difficult to forge a coherent policy. Here it is necessary to conceive of two types of policymaking: that which pursues the common good and that which serves the decision-maker's own interests, such as reelection. Accountability checks can cause deadlock but may avoid the least desirable policy outcome, that is, the one that only serves the policy-maker's own interests.
5. We should note that aggregate-level data may be more appropriate for causal inference in this case. Welzel (2013, 2021) argues that the rise of emancipative values gives the younger generation a stronger commitment to democratic principles, which leads to support for democracy.
6. The TSCS Project is sponsored by Taiwan's National Science and Technology Council and conducted by the Institute of Sociology, Academia Sinica. Yin-hwa Chang and Yang-chih Fu are the principal investigators of this project. Datasets can be downloaded from Survey Research Data Archive (https://srda.sinica.edu.tw/index_en.php). For the command file, please see https://ttsai.weebly.com/uploads/3/7/4/3/37436347/replication_tsai2.r.

7. These items were transformed into binary ones because the results of analysis are easier to be presented and interpreted. Take the analysis of difficulty parameters as an example. There is only one difficulty parameter for each item if the variable is binary. Suppose we retain the four-point scale, every item will have three difficulty parameters. In this case, there will be 27 estimates with confidence intervals in our analysis.
8. The estimation of the 2PL-IRT model is conducted by means of the R package “ltm” (Rizopoulos, 2006).
9. We focus on the estimates of item-difficulty parameters here. The estimates of item-discrimination parameters are shown in Supplemental Appendix A.
10. The estimation of the unidimensional and multidimensional 2PL-IRT model is conducted through the R package, “mirt” (Chalmers, 2012). There are 76 respondents who did not respond to any item in 2000 and 19 non-respondents in 2020. These non-respondents are given the value of 0, that is, the average level, for their latent variables rather than being treated as missing.
11. The first control variable, concerning public satisfaction with democracy, is coded as a dichotomous variable. The second, assessment of national level of democracy, ranges from 0 to 10, in which 0 means total dictatorship and 10 means total democracy. The third, partisanship, involves four categories: independent, pan-blue, pan-green, and other. Five categories are used to reflect the educational level of respondents. Finally, respondents are divided into six groups according to their age. There is no measure of the level of democracy in 2005 and 2010.

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